

CRÓNICA. GA2-240202501-AA1-EV03.

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ANALISIS Y DESARROLLO DE SOFTWARE

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27/08/2025

GUIDO VAN ROSSUM

THE ARCHITECT OF SIMPLICITY IN PROGRAMMING

In the heart of the digital revolution, where programming languages shaped the pace of progress, Guido van Rossum stood out as a key figure. He was born on January 31, 1956, in Haarlem, Netherlands, and became a computer scientist who transformed how millions interacted with technology.

From a young age, Guido showed a natural inclination for mathematics and computer science. He graduated in Mathematics and Computer Science from the University of Amsterdam in 1982, and began his career at the Centrum Wiskunde & Informatica (CWI), where he worked on the ABC programming language and BSD Unix routines.

But it was during December 1989, while on Christmas vacation, that he started a personal project that would change the world: he decided to create a programming language that was simple, readable, and powerful. That's how Python was born, inspired by the irreverent humor of *Monty Python's Flying Circus*. As he wrote:

"I decided to write an interpreter for the new scripting language I had been thinking about lately: a descendant of ABC that would appeal to Unix/C hackers."

Python was not just a technical tool—it was also a design philosophy. In 1999, Guido submitted his proposal "Computer Programming for Everybody" to DARPA, where he defined that Python should be:

- Easy to learn and use
- Intuitive and readable like English
- Powerful and open to collaboration

He also formulated the famous Zen of Python, a set of principles that guided developers toward clarity, simplicity, and elegance. These values made Python one of the most popular languages in the world, used in fields like artificial intelligence, web development, data science, and education.

For over two decades, Guido led Python's development as the "Benevolent Dictator for Life" (BDFL), a title that reflected his ethical and technical guidance of the community. His leadership was inclusive and collaborative, fostering a culture of respect and openness.

He worked at companies like Google, where he developed the Mondrian code review system, and at Dropbox, before briefly retiring. In 2020, he returned to join Microsoft, continuing his mission to make programming more accessible.

His legacy was recognized with multiple awards, including the FSF Award for the Advancement of Free Software in 2001, and his inclusion in *Wired's* list of the 50 most important programmers in history.

In 2018, he announced his retirement as Python's leader, but he left behind a strong community and a language that continues to evolve. As he once said:

"Python should be as understandable as any text in English."